

Field Methods 302:

Barnes & Nobles: A Study on Third Spaces

Author: Connor East;

Advisor: Marrienne Bhonslay;

College: Champlain College;

Date : November 20th, 2024;

I. Fieldwork Site:

Barnes & Noble, one hundred and two Dorset St Burlington Vermont.

II. Project Analysis:



A diagram, from 1995, shows an interior and external Aerial shot of the location 102 Dorset Street.

One hundred and two Dorset Street, Burlington VT, has been home to the largest accessible book retailer in the Country, since nineteen ninety-six, Barnes & Noble. A location known

for its large selection of books as well as its cozy atmosphere. The exterior; an elegant collage of white wood with an interior brick inlaying. The first floor's interior features pristine white walls with wooden accents; the walls themselves draw your eyes to the rows of bookshelves lining the walls. Plaques hang above each bookshelf stating the Genre of work present. A small Starbucks sits to the right of the entrance, the fragrance of worn books intermingling with the smell of fresh coffee and scones wafts through the air (East, 9/18/24). The Cobweb-filled windows allow for natural sunlight into the building. On the second floor sits the children's section. Artworks depicting the *Cat in the Hat* and other stories line the walls. The right side of the room holds a small section for Vinyl and CDs, items not often used by GenZ (East, 9/28/24). Barnes & Nobles is a third space, a term coined by sociologist Ray Oldenburg in his 1989 book "*The Great Good Place*", or in other words an area which is used as an informal core setting for public life. The major function of Third spaces is to bind and create communities centralized around concepts and shared activities (shankerinstitute). As Culture shifts from an in-person to a technological model a reduction in Third spaces is being seen which ultimately has led to an increase in loneliness and anxiety particularly noticeable in GenZ but occurring across generational lines. (BallardBrief).

The importance of third-party spaces in the realms of physical and psychological health cannot be under-represented; In fact, the very displacement of Third Spaces infringes on the pursuit of personal self-development (Shukr). The doors to the building open; individuals of all ages, races, and socio-economic standing walk in and out of the building. A group of ladies, in their early to late sixties, sit and discuss their familial lives while sipping tea. College-aged individuals simply sit down by themselves, working on their UVM-branded

laptops, while sipping on their coffee. A man in his late thirties brushes himself off before grabbing a book to read (East, 10/5/24). Barnes & Noble founders, Charles M Barnes and his partner G. Clifford Nobles, would have approved of this idea (Meyers, 2023). Even during the Great Depression, they believed in information dissemination and the social good which could come from it. In nineteen seventy-one a man by the name of Leonard Riggio acquired the location with the intent of transforming Barnes & Noble into a global chain; a main staple in the bookselling business (Company History).

III. Conceptual Line of Inquiry

Isolationism, Internet-Dependencies, and Social withdrawal all have a direct correlation with the recent decrease in social location or third spaces (Shanker). This however is correlative and not causative and as such it became pertinent to look into the structures which create a good third space. Given Barnes & Nobles' longstanding history as a location built for socialization over similar interests (Company-History) it was a logical location for this field studies assessment.

IV. Foundational Information:

Located between the coordinates of N07•39'13, S82•20'47'B, S82•20'47E. and S07•39'13'W sits a 0.56 Acre location owned by Barnes & Noble INC (LR, Book #637, Page #647). This land was originally purchased on September fourteenth, nineteen ninety five, from Century Partners, by Barnes&Noble for \$44,883.01 (LR Book#420, Page #89). The building, originally a Cinema, only needed minor renovations and as such in two

thousand and three. Barnes & Noble was lent a sum of \$5,000,000 from the Lehman Brothers Bank FSB (LR, Book #610, Page #508). All major paperwork having been signed by one Mitchell S Klipper, the executive vice president of Barnes & Noble Superstores, INC (LR Book#420, Page #89).

V. Research Methodology:

Through emplacement methodologies, data relating to human connection has been gathered. A compendium of multiple hours of observing interactions, social and physical changes, as well as demographics have been compiled. Each of these interactions having been holistically and relationally noted, to discuss questions such as how the company functions as a collective and the relationship both patrons and employees share. This led me to research the network topology used by the company to gauge foot traffic levels and other similar metrics. The final major methodology used in this study would be that of sensory. Questions such as how the fan noise affected individuals' actions and choices were pondered as well as how the smell of books and coffee affected mood was studied. These however were only the major methodologies used. Other methodologies used for the synthesis of this project would be data analysis, market research, and archival retrieval. The major downfall of the approach used in the creation of this project would be the lack of secondary accounts from patrons and staff.

VI. Qualitative Observations:

For note, all of the following qualitative observations were taken between the dates of September 18th, 2024, through November 6th, 2024; a span of forty-nine days. This ultimately means that a more thorough project may experience different results.

One out of three security guards are on duty every day; Overlapping shifts are non-existent. Every day between 10 AM-2 PM there will only be one individual working register; An elderly gray haired woman in her early seventies , an androgynously dressed college aged individual with black hair, or a man in his early to late thirties respectively (East, 10/9/24). On the weekends an influx of individuals at Approximately 2:06 forces multiple people to work at the Cash Register. The networking schema used [/23 address] allows for a total of five hundred and twelve addresses allocatable over a four-hour period to allow for multiple devices to access and use the network. At most they expect three hundred individuals to be coming in over a 4 hour period (East, 9/28/24). During the week this location is mostly patronized by groups, of four to six, of elderly women between the ages of 50 and 70. On the weekend the demographics shift to the following: fifteen percent college-aged individuals, twenty percent of individuals were between the ages of fifty and seventy, and the rest being a diverse range of families with a young child, typically between the ages of six to fourteen (East, 11/3/24). Most individuals seem to go to the location for the atmosphere. The smell of coffee, scones, and books sifting through the warm air

VII. Interviews:

No formal interviews were conducted.

VIII. Relational:

A total of fourteen hours was spent on emplacement. A total of ten hours was spent researching academic journals and other online sources specifically. A total of thirty-six class hours were over the course of the semester learning the basics of field studies. In total this project is a conglomeration of sixty hours of data and data interpretation. All data points taken during this project were discussed with secondary individuals to get their interpretations of the data in order to decrease the potential of written bias.

In the case of this project, no major changes occurred in the enhancement of the author's thoughts on the topic of diversity, equity, and inclusion. The base project had very few biases other than that of the topic of Third spaces. This paper began as a discussion on third spaces and continued to be a discussion about third spaces. All individuals of all walks of life are allowed at Barnes & Noble; this being both a metaphorical conceptualization of the business as well as a literal proclamation from Leonard Riggio.

From a demographics standpoint: Vermont's demographics being heavily Caucasian means a lot more, approximately ninety percent, Caucasian American individuals patron Barnes & Noble. The remaining percent being mixed between Canadian Caucasians and black Americans (East, 10/5/24). From an equity standpoint: all individuals were treated with respect at the Starbucks and a mixture of books with diverse authors sat next to each other (East, 10/12/24).

IX. Conclusion:

Modern-day communal third spaces, such as in the case of Barnes & Noble, serve the community with a physical and social outlet for diverse groups of individuals. The central conceptual line of inquiry, Barnes & Noble as a third space, being a synthesis of a much larger idea. An idea that bookstores, and other third spaces, offer locations in which patrons can both socialize over similar interests as well as an escape into the nonfiction world of books. Through the data collected, it was revealed that individuals of all ages, sexes, and socio-economic standings gather at this third space due to its blend of literary and coffee-house culture.

However, some of the themes that began to emerge challenged the initial hypothesis. Some of the themes being, that of, cross-generational interaction [or the lack thereof] and the Technological usage within the space and by-proxy the evolving nature of third spaces. The lack of cross-generational interaction suggests a growing divide between generational groups, while the heavy usage of digital devices—particularly among Gen Z and Millennials—indicates a shift in how individuals engage with physical spaces. This shift from physical to technological had been anticipated however, it was still quite perplexing to witness. From a sensory perspective, it became apparent that environmental factors such as smell, lighting, and room layout played a crucial role in how individuals acted within the space itself. Even still, questions arose such as how third spaces could function effectively when individuals were immersed in their digital devices.

In conclusion, this study illustrates the ways in which Barnes & Noble aligns with Oldenburg's conceptualization of third spaces, while also revealing the impact of technological, generational, and modern socio-cultural shifts. The data shows that third

spaces are dynamic, continuously adapting to changing patron behaviors and broader societal trends. Future research could explore concepts such as the role of digital engagement in socialization or how businesses like Barnes & Noble restructure themselves to fit within the ever-growing technological landscape.

X. Work Cited:

- “Accessing Edgar Data.” *U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission*,
www.sec.gov/search-filings/edgar-search-assistance/accessing-edgar-data. Accessed 16 Nov. 2024.
- “Barnes & Noble Education, Inc.” *Edgar Entity Company Search*,
www.sec.gov/edgar/browse/?CIK=1634117&owner=exclude. Accessed 16 Nov. 2024.
- Bowler, Abby. “Isolation among Generation Z in the United States.” *Ballard Brief*,
Ballard Brief, 30 July 2024,
ballardbrief.byu.edu/issue-briefs/isolation-among-generation-z-in-the-united-states.
- Cabral, Lauren. “The History of Barnes & Noble.” *Back Then History*, 7 July 2024,
www.backthenhistory.com/articles/the-history-of-barnes-noble.
- City of Burlington. “Land Records.” City Hall, Burlington, VT. Accessed 18 Sept. 2024.
- Kılınç, Nilay, et al. “From ‘Inbetweeners’ to ‘Transcultural Mediators’: Turkish-German Second-Generation’s Narratives of ‘Return’ Migration, Third Spaces and Re-Invention of the Self.” *Ethnic & Racial Studies*, vol. 45, no. 14, Nov. 2022, pp. 2726–48. EBSCOhost,
<https://doi-org.cobalt.champlain.edu/10.1080/01419870.2022.2039400>.

- Martin, Aaron, and Amal Shukr. "Person, Place, and Pragmatism: Theorizing Urban Spaces." *Cogent Business & Management*, vol. 11, no. 1, Jan. 2024, pp. 1–17.
EBSCOhost, <https://doi-org.cobalt.champlain.edu/10.1080/23311975.2024.2350793>.
- <https://www.company-histories.com/Barnes-Noble-Inc-Company-History.html>
- N/A. "Court: Online Bookseller Owes New Mexico Sales Tax." *Santa Fe New Mexican*, 3 June 2013,
www.santafenewmexican.com/news/local_news/court-online-bookseller-owes-new-mexico-sales-tax/article_569da3bf-8b2a-543f-a7f1-080c688c27b8.html.
- N/A. "DEF 14A 1 Y86878def14a.Htm BARNESANDNOBLE.COM INC." *SCHEDULE 14A INFORMATION*,
www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/1069665/000095012303006870/y86878def14a.htm.
Accessed 16 Nov. 2024.
- Press, The Associated. "Leonard Riggio, Who Built Barnes & Noble into a Bookselling Empire, Dies at 83." *NPR*, NPR, 27 Aug. 2024,
www.npr.org/2024/08/27/nx-s1-5091174/barnes-noble-leonard-riggio-obituary.
- "2012 Vermont Statutes :: Title 09 Commerce and Trade :: Chapter 51 Miscellaneous Liens :: § 1921 Extent of Lien; Notice." *Justia Law*,
law.justia.com/codes/vermont/2012/title09/chapter51/section1921/#:~:text=%28a%29%20When%20a%20contract%20or%20agreement%20is%20made%2C,stand%20to%20secure%20the%20payment%20of%20the%20same. Accessed 15 Oct. 2024.
- Wang, Hongyu. "Self-Formation in a Creative Third Space." *Studies in Philosophy & Education*, vol. 26, no. 4, July 2007, pp. 389–93. *EBSCOhost*,
<https://doi-org.cobalt.champlain.edu/10.1007/s11217-007-9036-4>.

Notes Cited:

- East, Connor. *9/18/24 Barnes & Nobles Notes*, vol. 1, 18 Sept. 2024, pp. 1–2,
https://doi.org/https://docs.google.com/document/d/1BUjy2xs0iBrEwM9Q2vhO9CGaShL0qbr_6myQY2eZ4aQ/edit.
- East, Connor. *9/27/24 Barnes & Nobles Notes*, vol. 1, 27 Sept. 2024, pp. 1–5,
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1DfhFam0N2CimEPJUP-OXq0cOJC4eSIS44rGycxnqG_0/edit.
- East, Connor. *9/28/24 Barnes & Nobles Notes*, vol. 1, 28 Sept. 2024, pp. 1–2,
<https://docs.google.com/document/d/1dxGS4la3afBm7OPlvQl2d1Mmec2VvWa-wg7i30GKjKM/edit>
- East, Connor. *10/5/24 Barnes & Nobles Notes*, vol. 1, 5 Oct. 2024, pp. 1–2,
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1DI4qE8LP_yt_TRLzmH3bZCERq5pG0XbdO7IYuVEe1EM/edit.
- East, Connor. *10/9/24 Barnes & Nobles Notes*, vol. 1, 9 Oct. 2024, pp. 1–2,
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Hp4fnbMsqveMMslHZQdSWwSZ90UViRxxZW_6mXn_gbY/edit.
- East, Connor. *10/12/24 Barnes & Nobles Notes*, vol. 1, 12 Oct. 2024, pp. 1–2,
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1XTO92FwEt6hI5ilBn6kEMN3wNiazOTB_M2csw53akuM/edit.